

The Nick Chubb problem

Why we lose, and the one part of it either of us can do anything about.

It starts with the worst pick in the league's history

In 2023 you took Nick Chubb sixth overall. He played two games. Measured against what a sixth pick normally returns, that is -157 points — the single worst draft pick anyone in this league has made in four years.

The obvious reading is that you cannot draft. That reading is wrong, and the reason is in the box score: across those two games Chubb scored 10.6 points a game. A healthy early-round pick averages 14. He was not bad. He was hurt.

Do the same for your other five, and the pattern is the same:

Year	Pick	Player	Age	Games	Pts/gm	vs slot	
2023	6	Nick Chubb	28	2	10.6	-157	injured
2022	47	Elijah Mitchell	24	4	6.2	-94	injured
2025	39	Mike Evans	32	3	9.0	-87	injured
2023	51	Cam Akers	24	7	5.9	-78	injured
2024	52	Rashee Rice	24	4	13.5	-71	injured
2022	38	Kyle Pitts	22	10	6.2	-51	played badly

Rashee Rice was scoring 13.5 a game — better than a typical first-rounder — and played four of them. Mike Evans played three. Cam Akers seven. In four years of drafting, you have made exactly **one** pick that was simply wrong: Kyle Pitts, who stayed healthy for ten games and was bad anyway.

This is not personal bad luck either. Of the 36 picks that blew up in rounds 1–4 across the whole league, **26 were injuries** — 72%, with a 95% interval of [56%, 84%]. Almost nobody in this league is losing seasons because they misjudged a player. They are losing them because a knee went.

But there is a pattern, and it is not the one you would guess

Look at the age column again. Mitchell 24. Akers 24. Rice 24. Pitts 22. Four of your six were players who had not yet turned 25.

Split every early-round running back, receiver and tight end in the league that way:

Age when drafted	Picks	Bust rate	95% interval	Avg value
Under 25	77	23%	[15%, 34%]	-5.1
25 to 28	89	8%	[4%, 15%]	+2.3
29 and over	37	16%	[7%, 31%]	+1.4

Young players blow up **three times as often**, ratio 3.0 with an interval of [1.3, 6.7]. Note what the third row does *not* say: the old players are fine. “Avoid the veteran” is not the lesson here. Avoiding the 23-year-old is.

And this is your signature. **You take 67% of your early skill picks under 25.** The league takes 38%. I

take 21%. You are not drafting badly — you are drafting young, and young is where the variance lives.

What a different decision would have looked like

Not hypothetical. These players were on the board within twelve picks of the ones you took:

You took	Result	Available shortly after	Result
Nick Chubb, 6th (2023)	−157	A.J. Brown, 12th, age 26	+38
Cam Akers, 51st (2023)	−78	DJ Moore, 54th, age 26	+77
Elijah Mitchell, 47th (2022)	−94	Josh Jacobs, 50th, age 25	+141
Rashee Rice, 52nd (2024)	−71	Terry McLaurin, 60th, 29	+52
Kyle Pitts, 38th (2022)	−51	Terry McLaurin, 40th, 27	+27

That is hindsight and should be discounted heavily — I am choosing the winner after the fact, so it is an upper bound on what any rule could have delivered, not a forecast. But the shape holds across all six: the prime-age player two or three picks later kept playing.

So the rule is narrow

Not “draft better”. Not “avoid injury-prone players” — that one is actually backwards: players coming off a season where they missed five or more weeks busted 10% of the time, while the healthy ones busted 19%.

Just this: **in the first four rounds, when two players are close in value and one is 23 and the other 26, take the 26-year-old.** It is one decision, four times a year, and it is the only thing on this page you control.

How far to trust it

Two reasons to take it seriously. This is not a sample — every pick either of us has made on Sleeper is in it, so “67% of your early picks were under 25” has no sampling error at all. And the age gap survives a permutation test: shuffling the age labels 200,000 times produced a gap that large 1,690 times, $p = 0.008$, with no distributional assumption.

Two reasons for caution, which matter more. **I chose the age bands after looking at the data**, and I ran perhaps twenty comparisons getting here. Bonferroni against twenty tests turns $p = 0.005$ into $p = 0.10$. Thirty-six busts is not many. **Treat this as the best lead available, not as settled** — the real test is whether it holds in 2026, which nobody has looked at.

And before this reads as one-sided

My problem is worse and I have no excuse for it. I put in **11 waiver claims a season**; the league median is 35, and you are at 35 yourself. When Nabers went down in week 4 last year I lost a first-round receiver and never replaced him. You cannot stop the injury. I did not even respond to it.

Sleeper, 2022–2025: 798 draft picks, 1,089 waiver auctions. A pick’s value is its points in weeks 1–14, measured against replacement at that position, minus what picks at that draft slot typically return. A “bust” lands 50 or more points below that, about three and a half points a week from a starting spot.